

pine trees are chopped down and used to build a frame-like pyre within which the body is placed. A huge amount of firewood is also needed to ensure that a body is burned to ashes. It takes nearly a day and about 15 to 20 people to construct the pyre at a cost of Rs 5,000-6,000. In the open, it is difficult to control the flames and especially during the rains, it becomes nearly impos-

directs the path of the flame and intensifies the heat. From the fuelling point, the flame moves almost horizontally along the body inside the pyre. Normally, if burned outside this structure, the flame would move vertically and consume much more wood, adding to pollution levels. The inside of the structure is lined with firebricks that can withstand the intense heat. A chimney helps in the emission of smoke. As the structure is permanent, it can be used repeatedly, thus lowering costs and saving trees while being non-polluting.

Chulai had been developing the device for nearly eight years. Initially, he faced resistance from the tribe as it did not want to defy a long-standing social custom. With death being a sensitive issue, his community did not even care to hear him out and accept that the old method was damaging the environment. Even the Sein Raji Jowai local social and religious organisation initially rejected it as they did not want new technology to take over tradition.

Things changed gradually and the organisation spent about Rs 15 lakh to build the first such crematorium in Jowai (the second one is under construction now). The first cremation took place on June 21, 2007, exactly a month following the crematorium's inauguration. Realisation soon dawned that this was indeed a better method and that in no way did it compromise the religious rites. Now, almost 80 per cent of cremations take place in the structure. Though designed for a single tribe in Meghalaya, the crematorium can be used almost all over rural India, saving acres of forest cover and preventing environmental damage.

The president of Sein Raji Jowai, Challam, says that the government of Meghalaya has woken up to the positive aspects of this invention and is helping them with financial aid to build the second crematorium in Jowai. Also, Rs 35,000 has been given to Chulai as an incentive. Chulai, the sudden recognition has altered things. He still lives a simple life with his sister, wife and daughter. He was born a cloth merchant Mahim Rymbai. Chulai's son has taken after his father; he is a sculptor and is training in Bangalore. Chulai's daughter works as a peon in the PWD office in Jowai.

Asked who his inspiration is, he points towards the sky and says, "Trekirod". Trekirod is the name of the god as they in Jowai.



SUVASHIS MULLICK

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Natural resources must be preserved for our well-being. The crematorium will help in reducing air and water pollution.

KAMBEL CHULAI, Innovator

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sible to carry out the funeral.

In this new structure, all these problems are taken care of and only about Rs 200 worth of firewood is needed. The concrete structure, lined with fire bricks, leads to a chimney. The crematorium has two parts—the pyre and a kiln-like structure, which